

Matt Embree

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CMPM - 180 Moving Text

Project 1 Artistic Explication

For Project 1, I wanted to create an interactive experience where the user uses the mouse to drop paint splatters onto text, revealing the text in the color that lands on it. There were a few design choices that went into this project. The first being that the text isn't static, and disappears after being revealed. The second design choice I came up with was to use cut-ups from different poems. I used the following poems for my cut-ups: "Colors" - By Christina Rossetti, "I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud" - By William Wordsworth, and "Grass" - By Joyce Kilman. I chose these poems based on their descriptions of nature and mentions of color. I used the online cut-up machine to randomize sentences and took bits that stood out to me, usually including words that center around nature.

In the project, the user hovers their mouse around the screen, dropping paint splatters onto the page that fade away after some time. These paint splatters color the multiple lines of white text, making it now visible, but sometimes hard to read. After an entire line is colored and is readable, the text slowly fades away and is replaced with a new line from the pool of cut-up lines.

My two design choices were inspired by two things outside of class: nature and my current job at a paint store. I work at a paint store at the moment, so I'm constantly getting paint on my hands and trying to replicate colors people want to see. It's made me more aware of the colors in nature and made me see them more vividly around me. They were also inspired by the discussions we've had in class about the time aspect of text and the use of cut-ups. I wanted to use these aspects to make something that makes you think about the colors of nature and how they change, like the colors of clouds, sky, and water.

I was inspired by "The Nature Book" by Tom Comitta, using cut-up literature about nature. The passage that best reflects this is this: "The natural world described by Austen and Dickens is different from that of Plath and Baldwin and still farther from the early works of DeLillo and Atwood. It's even more removed from the time of this writing, when climate change is devastating the planet." I say this because I used multiple poems from different authors for their descriptions of nature, and I realized that every author has their own way of describing nature. Having different perspectives and styles gave a unique cut-up of different words and variations.

The temporal aspect of this project was inspired by the reading of 'Writing is a Technology That Restructures Thought', by Walter Ong. In part of the essay Ong discusses the differences in spoken and written language. How "Sound exists only when it is going out of existence.", and that writers like to pin down meaning and structure to words. Talking about words, he says, "To the extent that it makes all of a word appear present at once, writing falsifies. Recalling sounded words is like recalling a bar of music, a melody, a sequence in time.

A word is an event, a happening, not a thing, as letters make it appear to be.” (Ong, 25). Relating to the project, the words on screen represent the parts of nature that change in color over time, and symbolize that in their words. As Ong says, words are events, things that happen over a period of time and are gone after that time. I wanted to reflect that idea in my design; lines about twilight, skies, and clouds are some of the things in nature that we see as non-permanent.

I see this project as a representation of nature’s ever-changing color and beauty. Words that make you envision a colored twilight, clouds, and sky bring you into the space of the temporary colors. The interaction imitates something closer to how we actually experience color in nature: not as a static fact, but as something we catch briefly before it shifts into the next moment. In combining the cut-up method with this temporal fading, I wanted the piece to be changing repeatedly, with new lines generating a new meaning. While also being more like a poem being witnessed, seen once, in passing, the way a sunset is seen.

Links:

<https://github.com/mgembree/naturecolor>

<https://mgembree.github.io/naturecolor/>



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